

Psychological First Aid

Learner guide | SWP-026 | School of Disaster Response & Crisis Intervention

This guide supports a three-part learning sequence for Psychological First Aid. By the end of the course, you should be able to provide humane, practical first support after distressing events within professional limits.

Practice notice: Apply the law, organisational policy, supervision requirements, and approved referral pathways that govern your setting. This material supports learning and does not replace urgent safeguarding, clinical, or legal procedures.

Learning objectives

- Provide humane, practical first support after distressing events within professional limits.
- Apply the key ideas from What PFA is and is not.
- Apply the key ideas from Look, listen, link.
- Apply the key ideas from Referral and self-care.

Course structure

Module	Focus	Suggested study time
1. What PFA is and is not	principles, safety, dignity, culture, consent, and avoiding forced disclosure	10 to 15 minutes
2. Look, listen, link	immediate needs, calming support, active listening, information, and practical assistance	10 to 15 minutes
3. Referral and self-care	high-risk signs, protection issues, referral, documentation, and helper wellbeing	10 to 15 minutes

Module 1 What PFA is and is not

This module focuses on principles, safety, dignity, culture, consent, and avoiding forced disclosure. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Principles
- Safety
- Dignity
- Culture
- Consent
- Avoiding forced disclosure

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of what pfa is and is not in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of principles, safety, dignity, culture, consent, and avoiding forced disclosure. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through what pfa is and is not safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Module 2 Look, listen, link

This module focuses on immediate needs, calming support, active listening, information, and practical assistance. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Immediate needs
- Calming support
- Active listening
- Information
- Practical assistance

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of look, listen, link in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of immediate needs, calming support, active listening, information, and practical assistance. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through look, listen, link safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Module 3 Referral and self-care

This module focuses on high-risk signs, protection issues, referral, documentation, and helper wellbeing. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- High-risk signs
- Protection issues
- Referral
- Documentation
- Helper wellbeing

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of referral and self-care in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of high-risk signs, protection issues, referral, documentation, and helper wellbeing. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through referral and self-care safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Course activity

Use the accompanying worksheet to apply the course sequence to a short case. Your completed activity should show what you noticed, the action you would take within your role, and what you would escalate or verify locally.

Assessment preparation

- Review the distinction between: PFA principles.
- Review the distinction between: Look–Listen–Link.
- Review the distinction between: referral thresholds.

References and local adaptation

- SWEEP Academy Course Content Outlines, production blueprint for this course.
- The current legislation, professional standards, safeguarding procedures, and referral directories for the delivery jurisdiction.
- The learner's employer or placement policy, supervision arrangements, and documentation standards.